



Summary

Reference: RA130872/1

Sign-off Status: Authorised

Date Created: 12/05/2026		Confidential? No	
Assessment Title: Accessing Archives - Using LLMs for the extraction and contextualisation of data from historical archives			
Assessment Outline: This project proposes the development of a structured workflow pipeline for using large language models (LLMs) to extract and organise data from archival sources. The broad aims of the project are to create a repeatable extraction pipeline, to generate an open-source dataset, and to demonstrate how archival materials may meaningfully contribute to ecological and anthropological narratives of the past and present. Information extraction would be conducted through prompt engineering using open-source, pre-trained LLMs. Prompt design will follow a least-to-most framework (Zhou et al., 2023) combined with chain-of-thought reasoning (Kojima et al., 2024; Wei et al., 2023), decomposing complex interpretive tasks into manageable subtasks. Performance will be iteratively refined using a representative training subset until stabilised, after which prompts will be frozen and evaluated on validation and held-out test sets to assess generalisation. Target extraction categories would vary according to source type but may include species occurrence and population records, key historical actors and institutions, and records of trade imports and exports, that may meaningfully be used to construct a conceptual image of the ecological and human interplay of a period. Separate prompts may handle distinct data types, reflecting how archival form shapes archival content. Archival materials will be drawn primarily from the digitised collections of the Zoological Society of London and the Natural History Museum, alongside other open-access repositories. To provide a defined scope and test case, the project proposes focusing on the Congo Free State period (1885–1908), a historically bounded context in which ecological extraction and anthropological disruption were deeply intertwined (Hochschild 1998). A significant methodological consideration lies in the format of archival materials. Many archival sources exist as PDFs composed of scanned images, making their content non-machine readable. As such, a non-trivial component of this project involves developing an efficient pre-processing pipeline using optical character recognition (OCR) (Stewart and Sinha, 2025) or related techniques to extract text while minimising structural artefacts and transcription errors. The text will then be segmented into overlapping chunks compatible with LLM context limits. Model performance will be quantitatively evaluated using accuracy, precision, recall, and F1-scores against manually annotated validation data (Scheepens et al., 2024). Once satisfactory performance is achieved, the finalised prompt configuration will be applied across the remaining corpus to generate a clean, structured, and publicly accessible dataset. Finally, the project may explore the development of a higher-level integrative prompt or lightweight chat interface capable of synthesising extracted outputs into a coherent "local ecological narrative." Rather than serving as a definitive historical authority, such a tool would function as a structured interpretive layer, testing the model's ability to contextualise data across disparate archival sources and across temporal and spatial scales.			
Area Responsible (for management of risks) Division, School, Faculty, Institute: Faculty of Life Sciences Department: Div of Biosciences Group/Unit: Genetics, Evolution & Environment		Location of Risks Off-Site Building: Area: Sub Area:	
Further Location Information:		Working remotely from home, the Natural History Museum (NHM) or the Zoological Society of London (ZSL).	
Is additional GM or HG approval required? Only relevant to specialist biological risk assessments (GMM2, GMM3, HG2, HG3, GM animals, GM plants) except GMM class 1.:		Click SELECT to change <u>ONLY</u> if this is a GMM Class 2, GMM Class 3, HG2, HG3, GM animals or GM plants risk assessment	
Assessment Start Date: 12/08/2026		Review or End Date: 12/08/2027	
Country Location:	GMM Class 2, GMM Class 3 or Hazard Group 3 Risk Assessment :		
Relevant Attachments: Description of attachments: Location of non-electronic documents:			
Assessor(s): Santos, Phoebe			
Approver(s): Hayley Boakes James Labisko			
Signed Off:		Hayley Boakes (03/08/2026 12:16) James Labisko (12/08/2026 11:40)	

PEOPLE AT RISK (from the Activities covered by this Risk Assessment) *
CATEGORY
Post-Graduates



Risk Assessment

Who Made By	Date/Time Received	Comments
Labisko, James	31/07/2026	Rejected: "WFH" is not an appropriate title for your activity, hazards, and risk level summary (and as well as working from home, you are working at NHM and ZSL). Desk-based work or office work are better descriptions.

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1. Desk-based Work		
Description of Activity:	Remote work from home and from the Natural History Museum (NHM) and Zoological Society of London (ZSL).	
List those managing this Activity and their competence:		
Hazard 1. Repetitive Movements		
Staff risk discomfort or injury to hands and arms from overuse/improper use or poorly designed workstation layouts.	Existing Control Measures All staff must complete a DSE assessment on Risknet. If a staff member begins to experience problems that is thought to be linked to their DSE Set-up, an assessment should be carried out to assess the problem and to see that these can be rectified with reasonable adjustments. Staff encouraged to take regular breaks to rest from repetitive movements. Other work methods to be explored to reduce the frequency of repetitive movements or work load management to ensure varied work.	Further Control Measures

Hazard 2. General workplace equipment

Ensuring equipment has been assessed, people competent to use and used according to manufacturers specifications. For example, equipment such as photocopiers, printers, faxes, filling cabinets, etc.

Existing Control Measures

Filling cabinets etc are of a type that allows one drawer to be opened at a time or labelled warning of a tipping risk, heavy items not to be stored on top of filling cabinets where possible. All new equipment purchased to appropriate standard checked by a competent person before use (for example "Portable appliance testing".).

Users trained/given instruction on use of equipment and equipment maintained.

Any damaged equipment is reported and taken out of use (use signage to inform others of the status of the equipment if it is not possible to remove immediately).

When dealing with issues relating to photocopiers/fax machines such as paper blockages, equipment is to be switched off at the wall before dealing with the issue.

Further Control Measures

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Hazard 3. Lone working

A lone worker may be unable to summon help as a result of injury, ill-health, or an emergency, or unable to carry out a task safely while alone.

Existing Control Measures

The UCL Lone Working Standard is to be consulted in the event of lone working - this can be found on the Safety Services Intranet.

Use a buddy system when in work. For lower risk activity, your buddy can be remote and contracted by phone (WhatsApp, MS Teams). For higher risk work, your buddy must be close, but can be in an adjacent room in order to maintain social distancing.

Lone working contract is recommended as follows:

- 1) Contact your manager (or other buddy) when you arrive in your department
- 2) Make follow up contact every 30-60 minutes to say you are ok
- 3) Contact your manager (or other buddy) when you leave work
- 4) Contact your manager (or other buddy) when you arrive at home.

Please note that lone worker and manager/buddy are to discuss and agreed period of time for check-in's, this should be between 30 to 60 minutes but not more than 60 minutes.

Further Control Measures

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Hazard 4. Electricity

Electric shock / burn

Existing Control Measures

No unauthorised alterations or repairs allowed.

Equipment is compatible with supply and has EC marking.

Equipment is maintained and tested.

Equipment checked regularly for damage/deterioration on wires and damaged equipment is reported and taken out of service.

Further Control Measures

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Hazard 5. Hot surface/material

hot/boiling water from taps/kettles and microwaved drinks/food

Existing Control Measures

Care is to be taken when transporting hot food and drink between kitchen and office spaces.

Do not carry too many items which would make opening doors difficult and could risk spilling hot drink/food on yourself or others.

Further Control Measures

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Hazard 6. Manual lifting, handling or carrying

Musculo-skeletal injury from push, pull, lift load

Existing Control Measures

Full manual handling risk assessment undertaken where risk cannot be eliminated.

Staff have attended 'Manual handling' training.

Portering service available and used where possible.

Heavy, awkward items will be stored at an appropriate height to ensure travel distances are minimised and the potential of a heavy object falling on a staff member while being used is reduced.

Items will be bought in a smaller unit size and/or broken into smaller units before handling where possible.

Further Control Measures

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Hazard 7. Static or poor body posture

Postural issues may give rise to discomfort or injury and can arise through a poor or inadequate workstation set up.

Existing Control Measures

All staff will carry out a risk assessment when working at a new workstation or if they begin to experience discomfort or injury.

Workstation and equipment design is suitable to the individual (i.e., ensuring good posture and avoidance of glare).

Work planned to enable regular breaks to be taken.

Lighting and temperature suitably controlled.

Noise levels controlled.

Adjustable blinds provided to control glare onto computer screens.

Further Control Measures

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Hazard 8. Trip hazard

staff may be injured if they trip/slip over items, e.g., trailing cables, low steps, etc.

Existing Control Measures

Good housekeeping practices to be observed by all staff. For example:

Management of trailing cables and leads and the use of cable tidies where needed.

Good office organisation and layout.

Areas clear from obstruction (e.g., no boxes in walkways, deliveries stored immediately)

Adequate lighting levels and any lighting issues to be reported accordingly.

Office regularly inspected and damaged flooring or equipment reported.

Changes in level clearly marked.

Further Control Measures

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Hazard 9. Eye strain

Poor DSE workstation set up, lack of regular breaks from the computer screen and/or lack of corrective eyewear for those who require it can lead to eye strain, headaches, and blurred vision.

Existing Control Measures

Staff should be encouraged to take regular breaks to enable their eyes to change focus.

DSE assessment process in place, and if staff start to experience issues, they should consult their line manager and carry out a DSE assessment.

Eye test provision is available for eligible staff members.

Further Control Measures

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Hazard 10. Fire

In the event of a fire, staff could become trapped and suffer ill health from smoke inhalation, burns or death.

Existing Control Measures

Regular inspections are conducted of the fire alarm systems in the buildings as well as fire extinguishers.

Storage of combustible material and waste is minimised where possible.

Full building Fire Risk assessments are undertaken by UCL Safety Services Fire department.

All new starters (staff and students) receive induction, fire walk around and E-learning.

Fire drills are carried out annually.

Fire evacuation marshalls are appointed and trained.

Further Control Measures

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Hazard 11. Poor housekeeping

Untidy, dirty desks could pose a risk of transmission of COVID-19 and other illnesses.

Existing Control Measures

At the start and end of each day, all office users must ensure that:

All desks are cleaned with 70% ethanol spray.

Keyboard and mouse to be cleaned with antibacterial wipes.

Further Control Measures

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Hazard 12. Poor lighting

Poor lighting conditions may result in headaches or sore eyes. The lighting levels may not be suitable for the task.	Existing Control Measures Lighting is suitably controlled, with glare associated with artificial light sources minimised. Adjustable blinds to be located at windows where glare from natural light is an issue.	Further Control Measures
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Risk Level

With Existing Controls:

<u>Risk Level</u>	A - Very Low / Trivial	<u>Likelihood Severity</u>
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